

FIELD NOTE

**Your company has
a GitHub for code.**

**It has nothing for
what it knows.**

And AI has just made that gap expensive.

TWO QUESTIONS

Ask a software team where their code lives.
You get a one-word answer.

Ask a marketing team where their knowledge lives. You get a pause, then a list. Some of it's in the research folder. Some's in decks. Some's in a doc from the launch. Quite a lot is in Sarah's head.

Sarah left in March.

Neither team is smarter than the other.

One of them solved organisational memory
as an **engineering problem** twenty years ago.

The other is still treating it as a **filing
problem**.

One source of truth

Not “final_v3_FINAL_amended”. Disagreement resolved by review.

History survives

What changed, when, and — because every change carries a message — why.

Change is reviewed

Improvement is a process, not an accident of whoever last opened the file.

Everything is connected

A system where you can trace what depends on what.

WHEN KNOWLEDGE ROTS IN A CODEBASE

The build breaks.

WHEN KNOWLEDGE ROTS IN A MARKETING TEAM

Nothing breaks.

The team just quietly re-buys research it already owns, re-learns lessons it already paid for, and re-argues positions it already settled.

WHERE YOUR KNOWLEDGE ACTUALLY LIVES

~ assets the organisation paid for

- **customer research** → a PDF in an email thread
- **interview transcripts** → never kept
- **the campaign argument** → a deck, minus the reasoning
- **tone, claims, positions** → two people's heads
- **refined AI prompts** → personal chat histories

Every one of these is an asset you paid for.
Almost none is in a state you could find,
trust, build on, or hand to an AI system.

THE CONDITION MOST COMPANIES ARE IN

Rich in knowledge. Bankrupt in memory.

Compounding isn't a mindset. It needs
somewhere to physically happen.

SO I RAN THE EXPERIMENT ON MYSELF

I moved my own methodology into a repository and started treating professional knowledge the way engineers treat code. Not metaphorically — literally.

frameworks/	Versioned, so a framework has a history rather than a latest copy
evidence/	Research beside the arguments it supports, so claims trace to sources
workflows/	Written down as workflows, not carried as habits
prompts/	A library, so a prompt that worked doesn't die in a chat window

TWO THINGS HAPPENED, IN THIS ORDER

1

Structuring the knowledge improved the knowledge.

Writing a workflow down exposes the steps you were skipping. Versioning a framework shows you where you contradict last month.

2

AI became dramatically more useful.

The models never changed. I could finally hand them something worth working with.

The difference isn't the AI. It's what the AI has to stand on.

AI CHANGED THE MULTIPLIER

For decades documentation was a cost centre with a moral glow. It made you maybe ten per cent more effective, and ten per cent was never worth the discipline.

TWO COMPETITORS BUY THE SAME MODELS

One hands them five years of connected research. One hands them a brand deck.

The gap will not be ten per cent.

TO BE CLEAR ABOUT WHAT THIS ISN'T

Don't put your marketing team on GitHub on Monday.

Git's learning curve is real. The specific tool matters far less than the guarantees it enforces — and plenty of friendlier tools now wrap the same discipline.

What you **cannot** do is get those guarantees from a shared drive, a wiki nobody gardens, or the memory of whoever's been there longest.

Pick the most expensive knowledge your organisation produced last year. Could a new joiner:

- ☐ **Find it?**
- ☐ **Understand why it says what it says?**
- ☐ **See what's been built on it since?**
- ☐ **Hand it to an AI in a usable form?**

IF THE ANSWER IS NO

The knowledge isn't an asset yet. It's an anecdote with a budget line.

Engineers stopped accepting that trade a generation ago. The tools have finally made the same refusal affordable for everyone else.

Read the full field note

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editorialintelligence.co/writing/github-for-knowledge